AN OSINT STYLE GUIDE

QUICK REFERENCE

Version 1.4 · September 2026 · The full guide governs wherever this sheet is silent.

THE CITATION PATTERN

> Author, "Title," *Location* [Description] (Publisher: Date) URL/DOI: Locator.
>
> Author, *Title*, *Location* [Description] (Publisher: Date) URL/DOI: Locator.

Short works take "quotes"; larger works are italicized, or clearly underlined where a platform cannot render italics. Drop a slot that does not apply — and its punctuation with it. Anchor notes at paragraph ends or after a quotation, not after every sentence.

THE EIGHT SLOTS AT A GLANCE

SLOT	RULE	DROP IT WHEN…
Author	First name then surname; keep surname-first order where it is the person's own (Xi Jinping). 4+ authors → first three + et al. Editors, translators, contributors appended after a semicolon: (ed.), (trans.), (contr.).	*Never — fall back to the organization, then the title*
Title	"Quotes" for short works, italics for larger ones. Reproduce errors and mark [sic].	*Never — no title, plain description instead*
Location	Publication, platform, site, series, or archive. Italicized. ≤10 words.	*It would repeat the title*
[Description]	Kind of source, plus vol./no./report #/rating. ≤10 words, semicolons between items.	*Never — this is the house signature*
(Publisher: Date)	One parenthetical, split by a colon. DD Month YYYY for news, social, video, releases; year alone for books and journal articles.	*Publisher repeats the location — journals, papers, wires. Date: never; use n.d.*
URL/DOI : Locator	Full URL, never shortened; DOIs as https://doi.org/…. Then p. / pp. after a colon. Never count paragraphs — cite named sections.	*No online version; source has no pages*

THE MOST-USED FORMS

Book — Michael Beckley, *Unrivaled: Why America Will Remain the World's Sole Superpower* [Monograph] (Cornell University Press: 2018): pp. 25–27.

Journal — Andrew Erickson, "PLA Navy Development," *Naval War College Review* [Peer-Reviewed Article; Vol. 72, No. 1; A2] (2019): pp. 7–39.

News — David Sanger, "U.S. Expands Cyber Operations," *The New York Times* [News Article; B2] (12 February 2026) https://www.nytimes.com/….

Social — OSINTdefender, "Ukrainian Drone Strike Footage Near Bakhmut," X [Social Media Post; C3] (14 February 2026) https://x.com/…. Archived: https://archive.ph/abc123 (captured 14 February 2026).

Short form — Beckley, *Unrivaled*, p. 45. · Immediate repeat — *Ibid.*, p. 51. *(Locators take a colon in a full citation, a comma in a short form.)*

VOLATILE SOURCES — NON-NEGOTIABLE

- Archive every social post, Telegram/Discord item, blog, and revisable page at capture. Append: Archived: URL (captured DD Month YYYY).
- Add an access date to anything continuously updated: sanctions lists, trackers, registries, dashboards.
- A screenshot you did not observe live is a secondary citation. Open with "Cited in." Unknown provenance is F6.
- AI model output is F6 by default. Cite model and version, retain the transcript, never let it carry a factual claim. Disclose analytic use in the piece.
- Non-English: original title, then ["English translation"] before the location. Disclose machine translation; check quotations against the original.

THE ERRORS WE ACTUALLY MAKE

- Missing description bracket · missing p./pp. · comma instead of colon in the parenthetical · shortened URL
- Rating assigned by category ("it's a think tank, so B") rather than by track record
- *Ibid.* pointing at the wrong source after a reorder — check every one at the final pass, or just use the short form
- Three outlets carrying one anonymous official, cited as three sources
- A screenshot cited as the post; an inferred geolocation given as metadata; a link never archived

SOURCE RATING — LETTERS RATE THE SOURCE, NUMBERS RATE THE INFORMATION

Cred ↓ / Rel →	A	B	C	D	E	F
1	A1	B1	C1	D1	E1	F1
2	A2	B2	C2	D2	E2	F2
3	A3	B3	C3	D3	E3	F3
4	A4	B4	C4	D4	E4	F4
5	A5	B5	C5	D5	E5	F5
6	A6	B6	C6	D6	E6	F6

GREEN — core evidence
YELLOW — frame and corroborate
ORANGE — weak; caveat in a footnote
RED / GRAY — may show a claim exists, never that it is true

A Highly Reliable · B Usually · C Fairly · D Not Usually · E Unreliable · F Unknown
1 Confirmed · 2 Probable · 3 Possible · 4 Doubtful · 5 Improbable · 6 Unknown

ESTIMATIVE LANGUAGE — USE THESE WORDS, NOT OTHERS

almost certainly	95–99%
very likely	80–95%
likely	55–80%
roughly even	45–55%
unlikely	20–45%
very unlikely	05–20%
almost no chance	01–05%

Do not mix verbal and numeric in one sentence. Avoid "possible," "could," "may," and "might" as estimates. State likelihood and confidence (high / moderate / low) separately — they are different measurements.